a steep drop from the peak of 50 per cent it had achieved in the 2019 Lok Sabha election. There of course exists a perfectly plausible explanation for that deficit, since it's precisely the extra buoyancy brought by the Modi factor that went AWOL in this election. However, party audits tend to be sterner in their pursuit of alternative explanations and it was a mark of the times that Yogi's speech did not seem to resonate with party workers as strongly as Maurya's did. The narrative of cadre dissatisfaction with the state government, thus, came to be the focus.

IT'S ORGANISATION VERSUS GOVERNMENT

The disconnect between the party organisation and the government was palpable through the various speeches. Maurya and Chaudhary spoke as if exclusively on behalf of the organisation, and the CM countered by questioning why workers couldn't respond to the Opposition's "negativity". "While good morning messages can be sent on smartphones, why wasn't the Opposition's spread of lies countered?" Yogi asked at the meet.

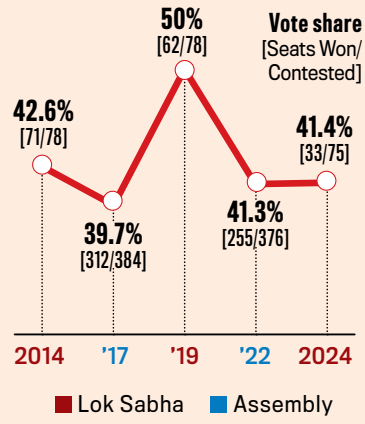
This divergence in messaging only amplified the rumblings of discontent on the ground. As a senior UP BJP leader told INDIA TODAY, "The statements of the CM and deputy CM were going in different directions. It set tongues wagging within the party. Many MLAs and party functionaries have claimed that officials of their own government did not listen to them but the chief minister did not take their concerns seriously. If things remain the same, we will have to pay for it. The Opposition is happy seeing our divided house."

The voting patterns seen in the Lok Sabha poll are also shaping the debate, says the veteran. The rationale for the Maurya camp's push for a leadership change in UP comes from how a major chunk of the OBC and Dalit electorate moved away from the BJP. To reach out to them again, this section within the party feels that the BJP should appoint an OBC or a Dalit CM. Does the contention carry weight? Well, the BJP's rise in UP was made possible by an umbrella coalition of forward castes, non-Jatav Dalits and non-Yadav OBCs. And according to a Lokniti-CSDS (Centre for the Study of Developing Societies) post-poll survey, even as forward castes continue to back the BJP overwhelmingly, the saffron party and its allies managed to retain only 29 per cent of the non-Jatav Dalit vote and 61 per cent and 59 per cent of the Kurmi-Koeri and other non-Yadav OBC vote, respectively. This is in stark contrast to the 2019 figures: 48 per cent, 80 per cent and 72 per cent, respectively.

But Yogi's supporters insist that his popularity remains high. They argue that his image as a tough CM and 'bulldozer baba' has helped the BJP create a narrative of improved law and order in the state. A senior functionary claims, "To challenge the Samajwadi Party (SP), the BJP needs a law and order narrative and only Yogi can deliver that. He still has a great connection with the masses. After taking feedback from various party MLAs, he has also transferred more than a dozen district magistrates and police superintendents, and a further rejig is likely, to assuage the anger of party cadre and workers." He also added that the central leadership should review the working of the state unit, right up from the booth level, and take action against those who "worked against the interests of the party".

FROM ZENITH TO SETBACK

How the BJP's fortunes in Uttar Pradesh soared and then faltered over the past decade



RUMBLINGS AMONG THE ALLIES TOO

The internal strife within the BJP has not gone unnoticed by its allies. Union minister of state Anupriya Patel, who leads the Apna Dal (Soneylal), recently stated in an interview that she knew from the third phase of elections that the going was not smooth. She even claimed to have tried to communicate it to the BJP leadership, more or less implying that it failed to understand her concerns. Sources close to her claim a deeper concern about the shift in Dalit and OBC votes to the SP-Congress combine.

Similarly, NISHAD party chief and cabinet minister Sanjay Nishad criticised the government's use of bulldozers against the poor instead of the mafia and warned that "*garib ko ujadenge to wo hamein rajneeti mein ujadega* (Uproot the poor, and they will uproot us in politics)". While BJP functionaries claim these statements are merely "pressure tactics", they underscore the growing unease among the allies.

J.P.S. Rathore, a minister in the UP government, attempted to downplay the divisions: "A wrong narrative has been propagated by the Opposition that we are divided. It happens in every party when results are not in one's favour, but we are hopeful of bouncing back." With assembly bypolls to 10 seats on the horizon, the ruling party's internal rifts have given new hope to an already upbeat Opposition. As for Yogi, he has largely kept a monk-like silence through this crisis, a silence that speaks volumes in the current political climate. As a leader once marked out for the future, it may not be too easy to relegate him to the past—as the BJP often does with more lightweight CMs. Moreover, there's the question of his proximity to the RSS. It may be in the best interests of all sides to find a middle ground before it's too late. ■